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Quill & Bytes: A Qualitative Analysis on the Perceived Impacts of AI-Based Paraphrasing Tools in Academic Writing and Performance toward Higher Education Students

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Abstract

AI-based paraphrasing tools provide essential support for students to overcome the challenges they experience in academic writing. These tools boast technical features to its users to effectively restructure concepts and ideas. The current study is focused on determining the perspective of students in using AI-based paraphrasing tools in academic writing. Based on this, this qualitative descriptive study sought to realize the following objectives: (1) How students perceive the impact of AI-based paraphrasing tools on the quality and originality of their academic writing, and (2) The factors influencing students' decisions to adopt or refrain from using AI-based paraphrasing tools in their academic writing. The study administered a structured interview to five undergraduate students through thematic analysis it was able to uncover the five reoccurring themes towards the impact of AI-based paraphrasing tools which can be simplified as follows: time-saving tool; quality of outputs; originality of works; academic integrity; and students' academic performance. Furthermore, five reoccurring factors that influence the students' decisions, the factors being: determining factors; preferred discipline; role of academic guidelines and policies; accuracy and trustworthiness; and peer influence. These findings yield a profound insight and understanding of the experiences of students in using AI-based paraphrasing in academic writing.

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1. Introduction

Writing requires practice. This process demands mastery of the chosen language, including choosing appropriate words, considering grammar rules, placing punctuation marks correctly, and employing proper diction to compose a well-structured paragraph that effectively conveys the intended concepts to readers. Effective writing demands a systematic approach. As a result, many students view writing tasks as challenging [1]. Given that writing is a crucial task, as it demands the use of one's abilities, there are techniques that experts suggest easing its process. One of these techniques is paraphrasing, which involves restating ideas and concepts using the student's own words. Aside from aiding comprehension, paraphrasing is utilized to facilitate a smoother and more cohesive flow in the writing process. However, one of the challenges faced by students in writing is their inability to rephrase ideas and concepts [2].

Additionally, students often find paraphrasing difficult as they simply repeat the words of the original text. Paraphrasing is a fundamental skill in academic writing. With that, it also requires critical thinking skills and excellent reading abilities. It means that paraphrasing techniques do not solely rely on one's ability in writing but also proficiency in understanding and using critical thinking skills to find a better way of rewriting ideas and concepts. Furthermore, it is revealed that writers employ paraphrasing techniques in distinctive styles and manners, influenced by their decisions on information selection, language usage, and paragraph construction [3]. This explains why students experience certain limitations in utilizing the paraphrasing technique.

It is important to note that the essence of introducing the paraphrasing technique is to make the writing process easier and to help students make concepts more understandable. Thus, this technique does not encourage any form of plagiarism. Therefore, aside from paraphrasing techniques, students must also practice the correct way of citing and follow ethical guidelines to avoid solely quoting ideas, concepts, and theories from sources. Students must be aware of the consequences they may face once they commit this form of academic dishonesty [4]. Nowadays, there are various paraphrasing tools available on the internet that help students avoid plagiarism. These AI-based paraphrasing tools were designed to rearrange sentences from one structure to another without changing the meaning. Moreover, AI-based paraphrasing tools are utilized in writing for the reason that this offers flexibility and saves time in the writing process, which also allows students to foster their skills in writing as it provides timely feedback and suggestions on how ideas and concepts can be rewritten [5].

2. Research questions

This study aims to investigate the perspective of students in using AI-based paraphrasing tools in their academic writing with this being said, the following research questions were addressed:

1. How do students perceive the impact of AI-based paraphrasing tools on the quality and originality of their academic writing?
2. What are the factors influencing students' decisions to adopt or refrain from using AI-based paraphrasing tools in their academic writing?

3. Methodology

3.1 Research design

This study employed a qualitative descriptive research design following [6] to investigate the overall perceptions of the students about the use of AI-based paraphrasing tools in academic writing. Moreover, this design is chosen for its nature to systematically explore the characteristics of a phenomenon which provides an avenue for researchers to accurately capture patterns and themes emerging from the unique experiences of individuals [7].

3.2 Respondents

This research investigation purposively selected students who are exposed to AI-based paraphrasing tools in writing their academic papers. A total of five respondents enrolled in the College of Teacher Education at Western Mindanao State University took part, and all submitted their approval for a one-on-one interview with the researchers which is a sufficient sample size to reach the point of saturation [8].

3.3 Data Gathering and Analysis

The present study utilized a structured type of interview questions that went through validation phases in order to ensure that the interview questions were in line with the research questions and to free from any potential bias against the participants. The validation process was conducted by our research advisers and college professors with doctorate degrees. The set of interview questions employed by the study was also pre-tested on two students enrolled in the same university afterward, consents were collected from five students who will participate in the one-on-one interview. At the end of the interview, the audio recordings collected from the interviews were kept strictly confidential and were not shared with non-affiliates of the present study. Furthermore, the responses of the interviewees were transcribed and analyzed using thematic analysis which enabled the researcher to discover reoccurring patterns and common themes [9].

4. Results and Discussion

There are two (2) classifications discussed in this current study, which are: (1) The students' perceptions towards the impact of AI-based paraphrasing tools on the quality and originality of academic writing, and (2) Factors influencing the students' decisions to adopt or refrain from using AI-based paraphrasing tools in their academic writing.

4.1 The Students' Perceptions towards the Impact of AI-based Paraphrasing Tools on the Quality and Originality of their Academic Writing

Five reoccurring themes were analyzed from the responses of the participants. This suggests that there are five different ways students perceive the impact of AI-based paraphrasing tools on the quality and originality of their academic writing. These perspectives involve the following:

4.1.1 Time-saving Tool

4 out of 5 or 80% of the respondents stated that they frequently use AI-based paraphrasing tools every time they want to save time in paraphrasing. In addition, the respondents also emphasized that they utilize AI-based paraphrasing tools to improve parts of their essays and write-ups.

The following are the extracted excerpts:

"... I utilize AI-based paraphrasing tools such as Quillbot and Grammarly specifically when I have writing tasks. I frequently use it when given an assignment or a requirement that needs to be accomplished right away since this can aid in thinking faster and as well as having a coherent type of essay." (Participant 1)

"...I first used an AI-based paraphrasing tool, I was somehow amazed at how it was able to generate and paraphrase the paragraph for like a few seconds or minutes, depending on how lengthy or wordy the sentences you paste there... So, in line with how I frequently used it, I only used AI-based paraphrasing tools when in need, specifically in a manner where I wanted to improve a particular sentence." (Participant 2)

"... I do not usually use paraphrasing tools, always, but I use them when I want to paraphrase a paragraph or an essay that requires less time compared to when I do it manually... AI-based paraphrasing tools take me a little amount of time, but it saves me a lot of time." (Participant 3)

"... I feel like, I need to use it. For instance, I am having a hard time paraphrasing a certain paragraph or sentence. I also use these tools if I want to correct the grammar or make sure that the grammar of my essays is correct. I can also say that AI-based paraphrasing tool saves me time to accomplish my writing tasks."

(Participant 5)

According to the statements shared by the participants, facing difficulties in paraphrasing becomes one of the factors influencing their decisions regarding the frequency of using AI-based paraphrasing tools. Another factor is the amount of time they save in writing. Additionally, the participants highlighted that AI-based paraphrasing tools help them produce high-quality written output due to the writing assistance features it offer.

4.1.2 Quality of Outputs

It is shown here that 4 out of 5 or 80% of the respondents emphasized that AI-based paraphrasing tools assist them in paraphrasing by suggesting synonymous words and enhancing the structure of their academic write-ups. Furthermore, it proves that AI-based paraphrasing tools help students overcome challenges encountered in writing particularly in terms of vocabulary and grammar enabling them to further elaborate ideas and concepts. These perspectives involve the following:

The following are the extracted excerpts:

“... AI-based paraphrasing tools help me overcome the challenges in terms of writing. Especially, when I am experiencing writer's block this tool helps me to have another type of idea or gives me some ideas regarding the answer. This also helps me to check if my grammar is correct and as well as to gather some vocabulary words which I then apply even though in my succeeding writing.” (Participant 1)

“... One of the advantages I would say is the fact that it enhances the vocabulary you used in the sentence in just a few seconds or minutes, which makes it easier on your end especially when you're out of words, but your sentences don't make any sense still even though you already edited and paraphrased it yourself... aside from helping you improve the quality of your academic write-ups, it helps you as well to save time on thinking what the right words to put in there to just make your composition sensible.” (Participant 2)

“... The use of paraphrasing tools improves, and enhances our paper in the forms of grammar and its content, since not all students... The use of paraphrasing tools especially when you just randomly typing your thoughts, most of the time, those thoughts are either grammatically incorrect or lack of content so when you use paraphrasing tools the AI uses its technological capabilities to enhance and improve your writing.” (Participant 4)

“... AI-based paraphrasing tools help me create more substantial and good quality write-ups because of the features it offers such correcting grammar, punctuation, and suggesting words or more profound set of vocabulary.” (Participant 5)

AI-based paraphrasing tools help users by providing them with resources, feedback, and automated assistance. These tools also assist in rephrasing sentences or paragraphs while preserving their original meaning. Therefore, these are the reasons why students seek the help of paraphrasing tools to enhance the quality of their academic writing outputs.

4.1.3 Originality of Works

The data shows that 5 out of 5 or 100% of the respondents shared that they experience certain limitations when using AI-based paraphrasing tools. These limitations include tools suggesting faulty structured paragraphs and paraphrasing without considering the sentence's context. Additionally, respondents mentioned that these tools may affect the originality of their work [10]. They also emphasized that their university uses applications that could detect if students utilized AI-based tools in writing their academic papers. These perspectives involve the following:

The following are the extracted excerpts:

“... I utilize the paraphrasing tool, when it paraphrases it gives us a nonsense type of sentence in which the construction is somehow faulty. That's why I think that we should not rely too much on that paraphrasing tool and as human beings we must double-check it.” (Participant 1)

“... When it comes to its limitation, I would say that there are moments where the paraphrased sentences don't make any sense at all, or it is too far from the original form of the sentence which makes it confusing and makes the whole sentence out of its original context... AI-based paraphrasing tools. So aside from its a challenge, it would be a problem as well, since there may be accumulated punishments given if found that your composed academic write-ups are purely AI-generated text based on their AI Content Detector.” (Participant 2)

“... using AI-based paraphrasing tools is sometimes paraphrasing without considering the meaning. It will just paraphrase the structure of the paragraph.” (Participant 3)

“... AI paraphrasing tools, especially in higher education, can easily be tracked especially if you are submitting your research paper like that, academic papers, you most probably going to be labeled failed mark by your professor if he/she finds out that you used AI paraphrasing tools.” (Participant 4)

“... I experience in using AI-based paraphrasing tools is it does not entirely consider the context of the sentence. When it paraphrases it does not align with the meaning or with what I am trying to say in my paragraph or sentence. Another thing is it suggests words that are also far from the context... That's why it is important to double-check and to not just merely copy-paste everything from these tools” (Participant 5)

The responses imply that AI-based paraphrasing tools can offer valuable assistance to its users in writing. However, despite its advantages, these tools have limitations, particularly understanding context, tone, and creativity, which are fundamental in writing. Moreover, the respondents highlighted that over-reliance on AI-based paraphrasing tools could lead to a loss of originality and might negatively impact the overall quality of written outputs (Hirvela, 2013).

4.1.5 Students' Academic Performance

5 out of 5 or 100% of the participants shared their experiences in using AI-based paraphrasing tools and its impact on their academic performance. All participants stated that AI-based paraphrasing tool positively impacted their academic performance. Participants 1 and 2 highlighted that aside from achieving good grades these tools beneficially influenced their writing skills through demonstrating some techniques in paraphrasing that they continuously apply in writing. Participant 3, 4, and 5 stated that using paraphrasing tools positively impacted their grades since it allowed them to accomplish a good-quality writing task [11].

The following are the extracted excerpts:

“... AI-based paraphrasing tools positively impacted my grades since through this A.I. paraphrasing tool I have garnered some techniques in writing specifically in the vocabulary aspect in which I learned a lot of things and a lot of synonymous words. This helped me become skillful since through that A.I. I learned how to make my sentences coherent and through this, I may say that I improved my writing skills.” (Participant 1)

“... I have used this tool to enhance the title of my research since I think it is a bit boring and not catchy at all. So, when I used the paraphrasing tool to paraphrase it, it became more pleasing, and the new title was more inclined to the study itself. Then later, the news went to me that my work was accepted and published. So, it did have a positive impact since I was able to publish my study and was able to work on my INC afterward, and this outcome would've been there if I hesitated to use the tool and choose the best paraphrased title I could get.” (Participant 2)

“... I think one of the instances that I have experienced where AI-based paraphrasing tools have impacted my academic assignments in a positive form is helping me accomplish tasks in the littlest time possible on the negative side is that the work will not be understandable than doing it manually.” (Participant 3)

“... it could be used when especially if there's work or there are things that you will need to finish as soon as possible, for example, when you're going to deliver a speech or give a message in front of everyone, and then you're not so sure that your words especially on that speech you provided that you're going to provide is correct.” (Participant 4)

“... using AI-based paraphrasing tools had a positive impact on my grades. Especially with the assistance of these tools, I was able to produce and submit good-quality written tasks or assignments. This is part of the reason why I keep using AI-based paraphrasing tools since it positively impacts my academic performance. I can surely say that these tools are convenient and helpful to attain good grades.” (Participant 5)

These findings show that AI-based paraphrasing tools significantly influence the academic performance of students. Participants mentioned that they earned respectable feedback and grades because of turning in well-written outputs. Furthermore, these tools contribute to the improvement of students' writing skills, as they can observe and take note of the paraphrasing strategies and techniques suggested by the AI-based paraphrasing tools.

4.2. Factors Influencing Students' Decisions to Adopt or Refrain from using AI-based Paraphrasing Tools in their Academic Writing

This part of the research delves into the various factors that influence students in their decisions to embrace or abstain from using A-based paraphrasing tools in their academic writing. These perspectives involve the following:

4.2.1 Accuracy and Trustworthiness

All 5 out of 5 or 100% of the participants shared their concerns about the accuracy and reliability of AI-based paraphrasing tools. They all emphasized instances where these tools suggested vocabulary that did not align with the context and tone they aimed to convey in the paragraph. Despite this issue, it does not prevent their decision to utilize AI-based paraphrasing tools [12]. Consequently, participants highlighted the importance of thoroughly reviewing the content generated by these tools before accepting it.

The following are the extracted excerpts:

“... trustworthiness. Sometimes, the AI paraphrasing tool does not accurately paraphrase a certain sentence or paragraph. Sometimes they might just change the structure and sometimes the meaning is not the same or congruent to the paraphrased write-ups by those AI. So, with that, it impacted me to not use it all the time and not to over-rely on the use of this. As a human being, I use my common sense or critical thinking ability as well when you are using this. We must say that it is important for us to check it before we finalize our write-ups.” (Participant1)

“... there are times that the paraphrased sentences are way too far from the context of the original sentence you pasted. So, better proofread the paraphrased sentence and check whether it is appropriate and will not contradict and confuse the idea that you are trying to convey to your readers. With these factors, it doesn't change much my willingness to use them honestly since I only use them If I need to, or for some occasions, lang where I need to enhance my vocabulary in a specific sentence, as what I have said, never rely solely on the tool.” (Participant 2)

“... I have encountered those challenges to accuracy and trustworthiness. I have mentioned earlier that whenever I want to paraphrase, for instance, some sentences will just suggest words, it will give you synonyms of the words without considering what you are trying to say. It just focuses on giving words that concern your grammar. It affects the trustworthiness.” (Participant 3)

“... AI paraphrasing tools which just emerged recently, have a really big gap, when it comes to AI paraphrasing tools, the accuracy, is more or less good at first, but these paraphrasing tools often have mistaken and also cause any grammatical errors when you use them, AI is not all the time effective when you use it for paraphrasing, and this alone made me think twice. So, that is why when I have academic papers, I would just rely on books, on other people and ask questions, and other sources on the internet, but technically use AI paraphrasing tools to do my job as a student.” (Participant 4)

“... I cannot deny that sometimes AI-based paraphrasing tools are not always accurate especially, with the suggested words and paraphrased paragraphs. As I mentioned earlier sometimes it does not align with what you are trying to convey or to the context. However, I still use these tools since they offer other features like grammar checks, also I double-check the paraphrased paragraphs or parts before accepting them.”

(Participant 5)

The results show that the primary concern of the participants is centered on the accuracy of the tools which signifies that AI-based paraphrasing tools demonstrate difficulty in understanding the content of the texts. Thus, these tools suggest unrelated words and generate irrelevant ideas. Nevertheless, despite this issue, the participants maintain their willingness to utilize AI-based paraphrasing tools while emphasizing the crucial need to practice thorough review and verification of the content generated by these tools before incorporation into their work.

4.2.1 Academic Integrity and Plagiarism

Based on the data 4 out of 5 or 80% of the participants emphasized the impact of AI-based paraphrasing tools on their comprehension of academic integrity and plagiarism. According to respondent 1, their university is strictly against the use of AI-based paraphrasing tools in academic writing. respondents 2 and 3 both emphasized the importance of maintaining integrity in writing while respondent 5 stated that it is important to follow certain limitations in using AI-based paraphrasing tools. These perspectives involve the following:

The following are the extracted excerpts:

"... we have here in our university in which the Turnitin that can detect AI which is subjected to plagiarism. That is why we should avoid copy-pasting all the things found in those AI paraphrasing tools, and we should be wise enough in doing writing tasks, and for us to also check if the structure is coherent and if the structure makes sense. So, that is the thing that we should always put in our minds." (Participant 1)

"... I guess it depends on how you will use this tool, it never encourages us to plagiarize at all, since it all depends on how you a person will use it on their behalf. For me, responsible use is crucial to be able to avoid ethical issues in the future and to maintain academic integrity. Hence, education, awareness, and a balanced approach to its integration are key components in addressing this kind of concern." (Participant 2)

"... it somehow affects academic integrity in a way that you would be paraphrasing every thought from different authors rather than incorporating your own." (Participant 3)

"...we must take note of the consequences if these tools are not used in the right way. When we paraphrase the ideas of other writers then we simply just copy them without credit, it is still considered plagiarism, which is unethical and can result in punishments. That is the reason why I think that we must remember to use these tools with limitation and be responsible." (Participant 5)

According to the respondents, it is important to not be dependent on these tools—the balance between using AI-based tools and writing skills. Moreover, the respondents also emphasized that it is significant for writers to follow academic guidelines and policies when it comes to using AI-based paraphrasing tools in writing. Participants 1 and 5 emphasized that paraphrasing another writer's idea without citation is still considered a form of plagiarism [13]. Hence, with these guidelines and policies, students can be aware of the rules that need to be strictly followed to avoid being subjected to any academic misconduct [14].

5. Conclusions and Recommendations

The current investigation aims to investigate students' experiences in using AI-based paraphrasing tools in academic writing. The responses of the participants reveal five (5) recurring themes regarding the impact of AI-based paraphrasing tools which can be simplified as follows: time-saving tool; quality of outputs; originality of works; academic integrity; and students' academic performance. Furthermore, five (5) reoccurring factors were discovered that influence the students' decisions, the factors being: determining factors; preferred discipline; role of academic guidelines and policies; accuracy and trustworthiness; and peer influence [15]

Based on these findings it is evident that students utilize AI-based paraphrasing tools for the reason of convenience, which is made possible by the features that these tools possess that aim to help users accomplish better results in their academic writing. The incorporation of AI tools in academic writing allows the respondents to effectively produce quality papers with the support of AI technologies [16]. This highlights the significance of AI in

providing necessary support, especially for students who are not proficient in the writing process. However, apart from the convenience that these tools offer, students also highlighted some drawbacks of using these tools, concerning the ethical and potential biases that are associated with utilizing AI tools in academic writing. Academic dishonesty and potential misinformation are major concerns [17]. One of these is the faulty suggestions of alternative words and phrases that do not align with the context that students are trying to convey in writing which may affect the quality and originality of the paper. However, despite this issue, students emphasized that they still utilize these tools and stressed that rechecking the suggestions is important in ensuring that the meaning expressed is accurate. Another factor that the students mentioned is the strict implementation of academic guidelines and policies in their university which restricts them from using AI-based paraphrasing tools in writing. Lastly, peer influence also emerged to be one of the significant factors that shape the students' decision to either continue or refrain from using AI-based paraphrasing tools and revealed that students seek recommendations and advice from their peers which yields trust in using these tools in academic writing [18].

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